

When the Process Stops Serving the Outcome

Process Drift, Procedural Dependency, and Reality Drift

Reality Drift Framework — Taxonomy Note #7

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The Basic Pattern

Processes usually begin as practical solutions.

A recurring problem appears.

A procedure is created to handle it consistently.

Safeguards are added.

Exceptions produce new rules.

Measurement is introduced.

Over time, the process becomes harder to change than the problem it was created to solve.

The core sequence is:

useful procedure → added controls → procedural dependency → process preservation → process drift

What Is Process Drift?

Process Drift occurs when a procedure gradually becomes more important than the outcome it was designed to support.

The process may still be completed correctly.

Every required step may occur.

The documentation may be accurate.

The intended result may still weaken.

The system begins protecting the procedure because other roles, tools, metrics, and approvals now depend on it.

The Process Autopsy

Original Problem

A real need requires a repeatable response.

Original Process

A simple procedure is created to improve consistency.

Added Safeguards

Controls, approvals, and documentation are introduced to reduce risk.

Added Exceptions

Unusual cases create more branches, categories, and rules.

Added Measurement

Completion rates, turnaround times, and compliance become visible indicators.

Procedural Dependency

Teams, software, budgets, and responsibilities reorganize around the process.

Process Preservation

Changing the procedure now threatens the structure built around it.

The process survives even when the original need has changed.

Why Processes Keep Expanding

Every added step usually has a defensible reason.

An approval prevents one kind of mistake.

A form creates a record.

A metric improves visibility.

A handoff clarifies responsibility.

The process grows through accumulated protection against local failures.

No one step causes the drift.

The burden emerges from the whole.

When Completion Replaces Resolution

Processes are easier to measure than outcomes.

A system can verify whether a form was submitted, an approval was granted, or a case was closed.

It may be much harder to determine whether the underlying problem was solved.

Completion therefore becomes the visible proof of success.

The process can succeed on paper while failing in practice.

Process Drift and Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, Process Drift begins when the procedure becomes more answerable to its own requirements than to the result it was created to produce.

The step outranks the judgment.

The checklist outranks the situation.

The completed workflow outranks the unresolved need.

The process remains coherent because every stage follows the one before it.

Process Drift occurs when preserving the procedure becomes easier than verifying the outcome.

The Core Principle

A process should be a means.

Drift begins when it becomes an object of preservation.

The organization stops asking whether the process still works.

It asks whether the process was followed.

The process stops serving the outcome when completion becomes more important than resolution.

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